time came, and that was not necessarily the firstborn. To allow them the independence and the financial clout to form a power base, mirzas were granted lands, or appanages, which were theirs for life and from which they could generate revenue. Kamran had been given the important territories of Kandahar and Kabul, Askari had Multan, while Humayun himself controlled Badakhshan. Upon Babur's death, all his sons retained their fiefs while Badakhshan was now given to a Timurid cousin, Mirza Sulaiman. Kamran, ambitious and driven, and the most tempestuous of Humayun's brothers, immediately invaded the Punjab and thereby deprived his brother of half his empire at one go. Humayun, meanwhile, inherited the title of Padshah and Babur's limited lands in Hindustan, and the khutba[†] was read in his name in Delhi, Kabul, and Ghazni, demonstrating his righteous backing by the ulema.

Humayun's situation was made even more fraught by the presence of many warring parties. Disaffected Afghan nobles gathered in the east, in Bihar and Bengal, making the situation in those lands intermittently volatile. To the west, the ruler of the rich state of Gujarat, Sultan Bahadur, was also showing signs of belligerence, while to the south lay the independent kingdoms of Burhanpur, the Hindu state of Vijayanagar, and then the sultanates of the Deccan.

So while Humayun, in his nascent Mughal Empire in Hindustan, had to contend with many chieftains from within his lands who were unconvinced about his claim to the throne, of whom the Afghans were the most dangerous, he also had to manage his brothers' fierce ambitions and shifting loyalties. He had to do so, moreover, while remaining true to Babur's peremptory and irrevocable request to never spill the blood of a brother.

As Humayun struggled to contain the fractious ambitions of his brothers while adhering to his impossible Timurid ideals, he sought a more intangible but potentially incandescent source of power. The Timurids had long been associated with Sufi orders but these were traditionally the Naqshbandi saints of Central Asia. Humayun sought to gain the support of Shattari Sufis—mystics from a highly respected Hindustani order of saints. Brothers Shaikh Ghawth and Shaikh Phul were actively courted by Humayun; they were 'not only immensely popular local saints but also experts in the Arabic, Persian and Sanskrit learned traditions'. In this way, Humayun was the first of the Mughals to use Hindustani intermediaries who were adept at both Persian and local forms of worship, and had